Week 31

JOURNEY

JOURNEY: ADVOCATES® · LEADER HANDOUT · UNIT 8 · LESSON 3

Doubt

BIG IDEA

Doubt will come to your students, and doubts that are shut down rather than heard are one reason many leave the faith after high school. Make your group a place where any question is welcome and walk with students through their doubts, because God can handle all of it.

Key points from the Leader Video

1. The speaker walked away from Christianity in high school after being told not to ask questions and to just believe, without knowing what that meant.
2. Many students leave youth group after high school, and unanswered doubts are one reason. More knowledge often brings more questions, not fewer.
3. Keep the open, authentic group you set up at the start: invite doubts about God, Jesus, the Bible, suffering and culture, and share some of your own.
4. Intro activity: each student writes down one question they're wrestling with. A Q&A session lets the timid hear their question answered too.
5. Equip small group leaders, and remind them it's okay to say "I don't have an answer," write it down, and come back with one.
6. Invite a storyteller who has walked through doubt; it needn't be dramatic. Some students have small questions, others a real crisis of faith.

FOR YOU

Before club: think it through yourself.

1. What doubts have I wrestled with, and which might be helpful to share with my group?
2. How do I usually respond when a student asks something I can't answer?
3. Which of my students might be in a real crisis of faith right now, and how can I reach out?

ASK YOUR GROUP

In small group: questions to ask your students.

1. What is one question about faith that you've been wrestling with lately?
2. How have people responded when you asked a hard question about God, and how did that feel?
3. Why might working through doubt honestly make faith stronger instead of weaker?
4. Which topics from this year left you with more questions than answers?
5. When a doubt feels big, who could you talk to, and what would help you bring it up?

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WEEK 31 · LEADER VIDEO

The full transcript

The talk from this week's Leader Video, lightly edited for reading. Times point back to that moment in the video.

Why I walked away

0:05 Years ago, when I was a high school student, I walked away from Christianity and went down a whole other path for a good long time. The primary reason I walked away is that I had questions and I had doubts. You have gotten up to this point now where you not only have all this content — we've talked about love, we've talked about the power of questions and the power of conversation — but somewhere in there, at some point, questions from others, information from other people, going to college, all kinds of different things are going to come at your students, causing doubt. What happens when they doubt?

0:56 I walked away because I was doubting. I asked a question, and I was told not to ask the questions. I was told to just believe. I was told to just have faith, and I didn't even know what that meant. I couldn't figure it all out, so I said enough, and I walked away. The statistics are still out there, and they're still pretty prevalent, that a large majority of students leave youth group after high school. There are a whole bunch of reasons for that. One of them is that when they have doubts, those doubts aren't getting answered.

Invite the doubts in

1:36 So this is an opportunity to open it up to your students and say, "Listen, I get it. I know you have doubts." Maybe share some of your own — and that's okay. Let's talk about them. Let's make sure this is an open forum. Weeks ago, at the very beginning of this process, we talked about the idea of having open communication and having a youth group that was very authentic and very open and invited the difficult questions. We talked about how those difficult questions were going to come. They're probably going to come even more now, because sometimes the more information you have, the more questions you have as a result.

2:14 So invite those in. Invite those doubts — whether students are not sure about Jesus, not sure about the existence of God, not sure about the biblical text, not sure about evil and pain and suffering, not sure about any of the things we've talked about, and maybe some things we haven't talked about, because there are a whole bunch of cultural issues that step into this that you have to help students navigate.

2:33 And that's where helping students navigate doubt is an incredibly important thing, an important tool at actually furthering their faith. Because as they get those things answered, as they feel free to express those doubts, that tells them that we as leaders understand, that we've been there, that it's okay, and that we're going to walk with them through those.

Large group Q&A

3:00 So for the introduction activity this week, we asked students literally to write down one question they've been wrestling with. Now, as a large group activity, you might actually take and compile some of those. You might do a Q&A session. I find Q&A sessions to be incredibly helpful. I open up the floor to students and just let them ask whatever they want.

3:24 And yes, you get some funny ones. I get a lot of dinosaur questions, and some interesting ones about Adam and Eve, and those can be fun. You can play around with those a little bit and have some fun with it. But at the same time, some really good and profound questions will come up, and the advantage to that is that if one student asks a question and another student is afraid to ask that same question, the student who was afraid gets their question answered. That can be an incredibly important and powerful tool.

Prepare your small group leaders

3:55 So I would encourage you to maybe do that this week, or to find a way to incorporate many questions into your large group time. Then, during small group time, you can drill those questions down a little bit deeper. But make sure, as you do that, that your small group leaders are adequately prepared to handle some of the questions. Based on your situation and the leadership you have in place and the volunteers you have in place, just make sure that they are equipped to properly answer. And remind them that it's okay if they don't have an answer — to say, "I don't have an answer," and to write those questions down, bring them back, and find a way to get those questions answered specifically.

This week's storyteller

4:38 Another important, powerful tool is your storyteller this week. To have somebody in front of your students who has actually expressed doubt and walked through it in some way, shape or form can be incredibly important. That story, whatever they've been through, will resonate, I'm sure, with many of your students. So make sure you know that you don't need to find the best story or the biggest story or the most compelling story — just something that lets students see, "Hey, I'm not the only one going through this. I'm not the only student dealing with this. I'm not the only person who has ever dealt with this, and people have gotten through it."

God can handle it

5:14 Because some students might just have little questions here and there. Other students might be at a significant crisis of faith in their lives, where they need serious direction. And after all that you've gone through in this study, some of those things may start to come up to the surface a little bit. So remind your students that no matter their questions, no matter their doubts, God can handle it, and that He has given us everything we need to be entirely confident of who He is, who Jesus is, and what our salvation means.